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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kcEE9ceXa64
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:22:36] For the Board of Ed to order, as we'd like to say, the hardest-working, unpaid board in the company. Welcome, everybody, and we will get right on with the update on the implementation of the Virginia Literacy Act. I guess I ought to check. Are we live? Thank you.

[00:22:54] Good morning, Ms. Conway. Good morning. The superintendent for everything. Well, luckily, I'm joined by an actual expert this morning, Dr. Emily Solari from the University of Virginia, who is a nationally known literacy expert.

[00:23:13] am very excited uh to be presenting this morning on the virginia literacy act and both what it is what it means for the commonwealth and for our students as well as what it means for this this board this is a longer presentation but i thought a useful orientation and just as a reminder no decisions need to be made today this is really a a first step um and a beginning conversation of which there will be many over the years to come i am i'm jenna conway i forgot to say that i'm

[00:23:48] officially our deputy superintendent of early early care and education um but really representing a broad swath of of the agency uh today this is cross division cross office work with a deputy superintendent uh richie assistant superintendent hollins and superintendent johnson uh christine harris jill nagueras and carmen couric from the learning team kim bassin brown from special education dr ortiz

and her incredible team at the office of school quality as well as the learning and early childhood team so it it truly takes a village on this effort um i'm

[00:24:27] representing us today but please know since the passage of this law we've been meeting internally As it affects all of our areas of work i'm also joined today by karen little who is our new strategic Implementation manager who's supporting us uh to to put this into action um it's a dense presentation but i think kind of an important level setting for the board starting first with the why or the need what the data on literacy tells us about the current state of things in in Virginia, a little bit of background on the science of reading and kind of why it

[00:25:03] matters for kids, then get into detail on the law, the Virginia Literacy Act, defining success. So as we embark on this multi-year effort together, what our vision for 2024 is and what will be different on the ground in the Commonwealth, and then coming back and talking about what happens when, this more specific timeline, talk in more detail about the important role of Virginia Literacy Partnerships, our partners at the University of Virginia, and then as always as you know you hear from me we do a ton of engagement so how I work with my colleagues across the Department of Education to broadly engage Virginia educators across

[00:25:39] the state all right so with many things I always think it's important to start with the why and a specific definition of the challenge that we face and why it matters so urgently for our kids all of our students here in Virginia so there's a few reasons and you'll hear me offer some detail on this on why we need a comprehensive law to address literacy in the Commonwealth as I'll detail over the following slides we've had declining trends and literacy in the Commonwealth kind of cross the boards with some real concerns about opportunity in terms of which groups of

[00:26:18] kids are most affected we've experienced significant setbacks as a result of the pandemic and the disruption experienced within our families and our kids within our education system we know when we look at the Virginia numbers that we have increasing number of at-risk readers and reading is fundamentally cumulative and so when we see early on that kids are at risk it means we have to act early similar you've heard me say this before as it comes when it comes to early childhood intervening early not only be more effective, but has lifelong effects. And we know now, and I'll talk a little bit

[00:26:53] about this and of course be able to refer to Dr. Solari on questions here, we now know more than we've ever known before about the science of reading and how to effectively teach kids to read. Because we do believe in Virginia we should have a commonwealth and we ensure all kids have the ability to read by third grade. And that's really important.

[00:27:12] I also want to say, as we get into this data, as you'll see, this is a complicated problem with a fairly complex solution, and I think that's really important, right, that this is not about pointing blame at educators, at families, certainly not at kids, or kind of -- but really sort of saying how, as we know more, we can sort of approach this differently and better support our educators, and I think that's always important context.

[00:27:36] You've often heard me talk about that in early childhood. This is not about going out and saying that programs are not quality, but how do we systematically think about better supporting educators, better supporting families, better supporting kids? And you'll see that as we talk about this need for a really comprehensive solution to do better by our families, kids, and educators.

[00:27:57] When we look at current literacy results in the Commonwealth, what we see is we have a very high number of kids who are below benchmark. So it's known as the PALS, it's now known the Virginia Literacy Screener, one in three kids are at high risk of reading failure.

[00:28:15] And I think this is really important to kind of slow down and emphasize. I think sometimes you think, "Well, if I pass the test, it means I'm in a good place." That is not how PALS has historically worked. So if you are not at the PALS benchmark, that is not being kind of at a B or B minus.

[00:28:30] That means you are at risk of reading failure. And there's a pretty direct correlation between being below that benchmark and not being able to read by by third grade and so we've got a third of kids k2 students in the Commonwealth right now at high risk of reading failure if we expand more broadly and we've worked very closely with our partners at UVA to do this and think about a multitude for three risk categories versus just this binary sort of are you above or below the benchmark we actually see that three-fourths of our kindergarten to second grade students either fall on the high risk or the medium risk category right so really when you sort of look at the

[00:29:08] data over time, what you see is only a quarter of kids are pretty well protected, and we can say with some confidence that they're going to be okay by third grade, and there's sort of three-fourths of kids, there's some level of risk happening, right? It's very high. This data is particularly concerning when you think about some of our kids that are more likely to be at risk. And we'll talk a little bit more about this when we talk about the science of reading, but I think everybody on this board can agree that literacy literacy is one of the most important levers for opportunity, whether you think about anything

[00:29:42] from doing well in school to doing well in college and career and life to a kind of health and behavioral health and mental health and social outcomes. And yet what you see in this chart is that children from our sort of most historically marginalized populations or subgroups are much more less likely to have the opportunity to read to learn to read and you see that you look at this is true in kindergarten this is true in first grade and in second grade so this is not just oh there was a bad year or this is a sort of a setback one time but kind of across the grade bands for our children that are black Hispanic our English

[00:30:21] language learners or dual language learners our children from economically disadvantaged households and our children with special needs are far more likely to be identified at risk at reading failure and then as I'll talk about in a second, experience reading failure as they get into older grades.

[00:30:38] We also know that there's a direct correlation between risk and then sort of ultimate success in reading. We talk a lot about third grade reading as being kind of this -- you've heard the common phrase about this pivot from learning to read to reading to learn.

[00:30:53] And so the third grade is -- it's also the place where sort of systematically we have our first standard of learning assessment. And the trend in Virginia as you look at this chart has really been sort of going in the wrong direction in terms of the number of kids that are passing their reading SOL.

[00:31:10] You see it sort of drops, and then there's an increase, and then obviously right around the pandemic we have a drop. Some note of optimism in terms of as we have really returned to in-person learning, stabilized as a society, you know, our educators are really stepping up and trying to kind of support kids to kind of catch up in all the ways, social, emotionally, academically, so you see an uptick

when you look at 21 compared to 22, but still significantly off from where we were a decade ago as a Commonwealth.

[00:31:40] These are state -- oh, yes, Dr. Halton. Any explanation or interpretation of the 2012 to 2013 dramatic drop? The dramatic drop? I don't know about that. I can find out about that. Was that coincide with a new SOL test and tougher cut scores?

[00:31:58] I think so. I think that's right. I don't remember, but I think that's a-- - Dr. Loving- - I think that's right, Timeless. - Timeless, yeah. And that's a good point, and I think there's been, you know, whether it's the shift in tests or changes in cut points, there's obviously some, there's areas of discretion around the state tests, and so the other really important point to note here is if you look at kind of the national tests and the extent to which this trend also bears out over the national.

[00:32:28] And so the NAEP is the national test. This is fourth graders, not third graders, so an additional kind of year down. And what you see is a similar trend of slight uptick, then some sort of sustained situation, and then a drop.

[00:32:45] And this is really significant when you think about, and I think some of you might know this, I've got a fourth grader right now, and it's a pretty significant shift in terms of how much reading goes into the learning across all subjects, not just English and language arts, whether it's lots of reading and math.

[00:33:01] science and social studies and the extent to which I'm really seeing this play out the shift from kind of learning to read to having to be able to successfully and proficiently read all the school day in order to be to be successful and so to see numbers like this and know that we've got a significant portion of our fourth graders who are not proficient or above is really concerning and you know while some of us would say well of course this is in part related to the global the national pandemic but just another data

[00:33:37] point here on while you'll see the yellow is kind of the national the national average and you know ours is really more pronounced and so really sort of thinking through you know what do we need to kind of do differently to sort of support this very real drop and in terms of kind of you know what is related to the pandemic what might be related to conditions previously but here more importantly how do we help and better support our educators our families and our kids to to catch up we also see oh yeah I'm sorry to interrupt Jen this is probably not part of you know where you're headed and I appreciate

[00:34:14] the overview of the Literacy Act but which of the benchmarks you know you You mentioned PALS as sort of a very good predictor of the ability to read further on. How does that compare as an assessment to the SOLs versus NAEP in terms of where we think -- where Virginia thinks a child needs to be in order to be ready to move on through the grades?

[00:34:38] So I know the most about the PALS, which we are doing some work on now to strengthen. I think part of what you'll talk about in the science of reading is the importance of really using assessments that give educators the information they need to tackle the most important aspects of learning to read.

[00:34:58] And so, you know, we had not made a lot of changes to PALS over a period of time, and I know we'd actually heard some concerns even from school divisions about how well it was actually identifying the children who needed sort of those supports and the extent to which it was giving you the information on how to individualize the support in education.

[00:35:15] So there is some work to strengthen PALS here. I know that there's discussions this board is going to have around kind of SOL cut scores and alignment there. I generally think the NAEP is a pretty good barometer over time. I'm not sure, Superintendent Bill, if you want to add anything there, but that's probably, you know, the most impartial of these in terms of really where kids are at and a kind of apples-to-apples comparison across the country.

[00:35:40] I guess what I'm not actually asking about the apples-to-apples because I appreciate the need to have standard assessments across the country so you can see where you are relative to others. What I'm asking is in terms of, and this is a discussion the board has had before when, you know, actually setting the SOL cost scores.

[00:35:56] I mean, you put the SOL graph up there as if that was the good measure for third grade, you know, success in reading, passing that or not passing that. I mean, do we still believe that the SOLs are a good measure for, again, not the quality comparison with others, but the absolute, you know, does this child, you know, belong in the next grade?

[00:36:19] Are they reading at an appropriate level to move on to the next grade? Do we think the SOLs are covering that? Do we think we use PALS data for that? Or do we think it's NAEP proficient? - So that gets to a deeper question, right? I mean, the SOL assessments are rooted in the standards of learning, right?

[00:36:38] And I do think, and I believe it's up for this board next year, that there is a need to, as we take an additional look at the English language arts SOLs, a need to strengthen those, right, which in turn would potentially strengthen in absolute terms the SOL assessment. So, you know, it's aligned with our current version of the SOLs. I think we're uncovering, and I'll defer to you, if there's more you want to add here, but I think we're uncovering that there potentially will be a need to sort of strengthen aspects of the

[00:37:12] SOLs as we do, you know, periodically every few years to align with the research and kind of what are the the skills and abilities that we want our students to have I guess what I'm asking is do we think the kids who pass the SOLs really can't read at grade level once she the ones who do pass pass do we believe they read our reading at grade level or not as a state you know I you know high pass yes and I think I think this comes down to where does one draw the cut point also right I mean the extent to which the new part of it is if you know if you depending on where you

[00:37:49] set that cut point they certainly do you know I think if you you know interpret more broadly no i'm quite sure i i understood that answer but that's okay i mean i think that that's the i mean the decision that this board has made sort of historically like you have said like yes this is the point at which you know it means in absolute terms that you know childhood scores above this is considered to be reading i don't think that's a forever designation right i mean i think as we get more information and you know even as you look at some of the the NAEP results in other things like it is something for this this body to consider

[00:38:28] I I don't I don't I don't I mean you can't let's take it from the other end and I know you get there in the presentation or maybe no you don't get there next speaker does but yeah you know the goal right now is to have a child graduating from Virginia high school be college or career ready right do we believe that if they pass the SOLs you know that we are would consider them to be college ready and is that born out i mean how do we know i'm not looking to pick on

[00:39:03] this i mean i understand why we're doing the literacy act to change the way we teach it but since you brought up the measurement side of it i'm curious to know you know what the professionals

think i mean because long before this board you know this particular group well the one right you know the composition just before this set the last set of reading cut scores i mean the commonwealth had cut scores from as long as we've had our sols right do we think that all of those cut scores were you know on target too high too low in terms of measuring the ability

[00:39:39] of the the capability of a child to meet the college or career readiness standard when they graduate so it's hard to answer that question because i feel like this is the body that makes that decision about where you draw that cut point i certainly think you know in terms of uh and we could we could certainly bring dr loving rider up here to sort of talk about right i mean that's the individual for each of the the times that this has come in front of that body who has said based on the evidence in front of us here's the recommendation on where you draw that cut point

[00:40:16] that does in fact suggest that the children who score the students who score above that benchmark are prepared um i don't know of any evidence to the contrary right now um and you know i do think you know in all transparency around the virginia literacy act that like as we look and i know we've had this conversation with dr harris and learning as we take a look again at the standards next year and then sort of think about you know you know asking ourselves that very question

[00:40:49] mr gecker about is this you know does do knowing these things mean that you are not only prepared to pass a test at the end of third grade but to be successful is the question you should ask with because the sol tests are rooted in the standards of learning um and so i think it's it's it's it's almost what i hear you saying it's you know it's like it's not only about getting the cuts door right it's about making sure that the underlying standards actually reflect the best science and knowledge about reading too and at the end of the day what we're looking to do is you know produce

[00:41:25] is the wrong word here but you know have a child who is capable of yes you know living life either you know first through college or directly in a career uh and have we been successful at that yes and i think that's exactly right both in terms of the longitudinal piece and as well as The data the data is is a flashlight, right? Like we also don't want to build a system That's get really good at just you know a certain test or you know Whether SOL or NAPE or whatever set of letters like it is really you know about making sure not only and then that's why This is that there's a huge emphasis here on curriculum

[00:42:02] Right in sort of making sure that covers the right thing and then making sure similar that we align our standards of learning as well - Ms. Mann, Dr. Mann, excuse me. - And I'm so obviously learning to shift my division perspective to this perspective, but I think maybe what an idea might help that I've used over the time, help me, I'm not sure if it's helpful to other people or not, is distinguishing between the continuum of leading indicators and lagging indicators.

[00:42:30] So without a doubt, as having been an elementary principal, how scores and the things that you do real time, you know, with reading scores with teachers instructional assistants, that is a real-time indicator that allows a current pivot. You move to SOLs end of year, except for very recently. Again, now you're moving down the continuum of lagging indicator, still informative and helpful and gives you a statewide perspective. But in terms of lagging, NAEP is most definitely a lagging indicator. But when the lagging indicator indicates something else along the way, then we want to come back to the leading indicator. So I guess, as I've tried to wrap my mind around this in the past, I take it out of the education

[00:43:08] perspective and i put it into uh uh worker safety you know a leading indicator is our employees wearing their helmets using their personal protective equipment you know not standing on chairs and

using ladders and all those kinds of things that's a leading indicator tracking that the lagging indicator does our work workers compensation go down uh and so those so i don't think it's an or here i think it's an and um but i think that from the field the leading indicators are much more actionable and that's where a lot of energy and emphasis goes that was very helpful

[00:43:46] thank you for that um and i guess the thing that i'm most excited about regarding the act which i think really goes to the heart of why it feels so difficult to get this right and we spend so much time perfecting how we measure things we do not spend enough time perfecting how we prepare people to do this work and the campaign for third grade reading have been sounding the alarm for many many years about the lack of explicit instruction in teacher prep around how to help students learn how

[00:44:23] to read we should not be surprised we should not get misguided and focused on you know bars bars are important we need those things we have an obligation but if we don't do the work of finding the educators that we need who are licensed to do this work with the skills they need to do it our children will be underserved and that's the piece that i feel we struggle with because that's hard it's hard to do that as the profession is struggling to hold itself together in the

[00:44:58] aftermath of a pandemic um it's hard and i just i'm so excited about what the act is putting forward because it gives us an opportunity to focus on that. And that's what we have to keep our eye on.

[00:45:14] Truly, we could we could really spend a lot of time trying to figure out what's the precise measurement for this and not go to the heart of how do we get the right people in front of children so that they can have a chance to learn.

[00:45:34] And I I'm excited about this act for that reason, because I think it offers the promise of that. And that's where we have to double down. I'm happy to understand the data and the news is bad. Let's get to work.

[00:45:52] - Yes, even if the news were less bad, we would still want the act. - Right. - Right, we would, I guess this is put in the context of things are going badly. But honestly, as I understand what we're doing and changing the way we're going to teach reading, we're moving to teaching reading in a way that's more appropriate and broad-based.

[00:46:16] - Yes, I think that's correct. I would say though, when you think about how we've approached this historically, right, that the sort of the focus in terms of EIRI and reading intervention has been on sort of those who are at greatest risk. And in that, I don't think we've looked as systematically as we could have, as Dr. Mann noted, about all kids, all educators, all classrooms, right?

[00:46:40] And this idea that we only needed to prepare some teachers teach children with reading difficulties or we only needed to focus on the most underserved schools and communities and so you know yes what is sort of great about this law is its comprehensive look and and i just think when you look at some of virginia's data you'll see where some combination of not identifying all the risk and then this sort of focus on a subset has you know led to a situation where we we need to think more broadly and i think that it is a significant amount of work as i'll talk about but um really critical um if you look at even the evidence which goes back

[00:47:18] to and i think is underlying in some of the work around the campaign for third grade reading but just the idea that you know a significant nearly all kids can learn to read if well supported to do so there are some exceptions in terms of children with more severe learning disorders or disabilities but you

know sort of systematically we have to think differently and we have to have a belief system that believes all kids can learn to read and that we can support all educators to do that which is you know sort of not what's currently happening the other important piece here and before jumping into uh the work itself and just i think a set of slides that underlie

[00:47:58] some of the complexity of the science of reading and why it does take work is you know again you've heard me talk about similar concepts when we think about early childhood but just how these early foundational learning really sets the stage for future learning and development and so you know beyond the kind of just the sort of adage out there about learning to read versus reading to learn you know you know again each year becomes harder and harder if you are not a proficient reader and we can directly connect sort of kids who are poor readers in third grade to kids who are poor readers in high school right and sort of more likely to be retained more likely to present

[00:48:37] challenges i get it if you cannot read like a sort of a high school day sounds impossible right in terms of that we know more likely to drop out um and ultimately it's associated with a whole range of social emotional physical and economic health outcomes and so it's not just about you know one test at one point in time um it's a lagging indicator as dr siebert noted that actually sort of carries itself forward and if not built on a strong foundation will affect kids for the entirety of their of their educational experience so with that what i'd like to do then is start to

[00:49:13] talk about just briefly a kind of a primer on the science of reading in part to demonstrate because some of us say well hello if i can just listen to one podcast or make this change like why you know why haven't we done that and if you really think about systematically what is the science of reading you know what does this evidence suggest and what does that mean kind of across the board across thousands and thousands of classrooms and educator preparation programs that we need to do differently. So lots of things out there, you know, science of reading, not one curriculum, you know, not just a sort of a saying or sort of jargon. It really is about kind of evidence from

[00:49:52] multiple fields of study that has demonstrated really now for nearly two decades a solid scientific evidence base on how children learn to read and sort of feel again why there are challenges there and this needs to be the science needs to be used to think about both how do you instruct children to read and then how do you identify reading difficulty so you can then adjust your instruction to meet those needs there is a ton of evidence on there we have top experts at higher

[00:50:27] across Virginia, including Dr. Solari, who's presented on this, you know, to our superintendents, to our elementary school principals, to others. We also have great reading if the board wants more on this. So I'm not going to sort of go too much into detail, but I do think it's important to note, one, that this is rooted in science and truly, I think, as Dr. Mann noted, that there's some real work to be done, like that this has not necessarily been fully embraced by higher education fully and based by curriculum vendors and as such we have a situation where we have not necessarily fully prepared our educators across our k2 k3 system to use the best available information use the highest quality

[00:51:07] tools to support kids to read you know you may have heard this before you while most folks naturally acquire oral language that is not true for reading right like you just can't surround kids with reading and they learn to read like Like it's actually for, you know, at least 80% of kids, it requires intentional, explicit, systematic instruction on a set of factors that is both focused on helping kids understand and recognize words as well as think about meaning, language, and connection.

[00:51:39] I'll talk a little bit in a moment about the simple view of reading, but oftentimes they also talk about you can sort of particularly, right, as all of this board is, as fluent readers, you might say, okay, I look at it, I recognize a word, and not fully understand neurologically all of the steps that it takes to kind of become a skilled reader. And so we use the kind of combination of both academics, educational academics, as well as neurology, and really kind of pinpointing at the earliest stages how the brain learns to read, which is connected to sound and oral language, rather than just, you know, words, words on a page, or, you know, worse, like

[00:52:16] asking folks to memorize words on a page, which is not an effective way to teach children to read. The simple, we've got some fancy graphics here. I didn't realize that we've got animation. You've probably seen this before. I'm throwing a little math in my literacy presentation here, but important to note, and basically the idea is you present reading comprehension as a product because it basically implies that if you are zero in area of these areas, like you're not going to be able to read to understand so really important whether it's word recognition decoding but

[00:52:51] developing kids capacity to assign letters and let groupings of letters to sound and make sense of that while also supporting their linguistic comprehension and we've gone back and forth and i think rather than thinking of this a either war what this graphic and this this view on the simple view of reading is that you need both we need to support our educators to be able to support kids to learn in both of these areas if you want kids to be able to read to understand the words you often hear are deliberate systematic explicit instruction in both of these areas simply surrounding children with books reading to kids a lot is not sufficient that will help them learn

[00:53:31] content and concepts and language acquisition but it will not help them learn to decode and encode spell and use those words this is almost deceptive though why i think this is a very useful way of understanding why you need both parts. I also think it sort of belies, well, like, well, if it's simple, like, why aren't we doing it systematically? And so the next two slides, which I cannot explain in detail, but will defer to Dr. Solari if asked, really start to get into why it is much more complex. And so when there's a reason we call this the science of reading, and as you see, what goes into decoding, right, which is sounding out a word and encoding,

[00:54:08] putting sounds together to make a word is actually quite complicated and goes to sort of knowing letters and groupings of letters and how that those work right being able to spell and that associated issue between reading and writing and oral language how print represents sounds syllables and meaningful word parts that's a bunch and you need systematic instruction there similarly you've got linguistic comprehension as well and content and sort of themes and how sentences are organized and how language works right all of which um you've got to have both of those and then you're working at kind of how accurately they're reading, how fluently they're reading, kind of are they getting intonation and meeting. It's a

[00:54:44] lot and I think that that's important to note as we think about okay systematically how do you bring this to programs particularly if they haven't been fully embraced in the in the curriculum that's readily available or haven't necessarily provided a strong evidence base or kind of experience or educational based in their higher ed preparation. It's a lot. So the simple view of reading is useful to kind of be able to explain to appear what it is, but when you really think about what we're asking educators to do, it is important to recognize, I think, the work as Dr. Mann noted. And then the even more complicated graphic, but as ultimately as everybody

[00:55:22] on this board had to do with the large binders that you get prior to each meeting, like it's not just enough to be able to read, to understand, like you need to be able to really be a skilled reader, and things need to get increasingly strategic and automatic over time to be able to read things, learn new vocabularies, social studies vocabulary, science vocabulary, you know, kind of industrial vocabulary, right, all sort of new words and concepts, and this hinges on pretty sophisticated language comprehension and word recognition skills.

[00:55:50] So this is Scarborough's Robe. I think it does a good job kind of sort of taking what appears to be a quite simple depiction of really and really showing, if you think about, again, your kindergarten, your first grade your second grade your third grade teacher making sure that they're each day within that core English and literacy art block bringing systematic instruction right to a group of you know 15 to 25 kids right all through different skills and ability this is not simple right this is complex and this requires strong foundational training as well as continuing and ongoing professional

[00:56:25] development in order to support our teachers to do this day in day out it requires more than just classroom educator requires the reading specialist the principal all the interventionists right it sort of takes a systematic approach with sort of you know support from central office and i think as i talk in more detail you'll see why the via vla is so comprehensive because we would also would not be fair to put this on the sort of shoulders you know i think as dr siebert and dr man know of just one teacher too right it really takes all of the teachers the educators and the folks who support them across our classrooms to be able to achieve this day in day out with an incredibly

[00:57:03] diverse set of young learners all right questions about the science of reading uh or dr salari i'm not sure if you can zoom in if there's anything you'd like to add that i failed to cover hi can everyone hear me sorry sorry i'm not there today yeah only that when we think about the simple view of reading we shouldn't think about it as simplistic and that's kind of contrary to the title but what's interesting is when you kind of look there's empirical data to support the framework and that's true across multiple subgroups of children

[00:57:39] modeling English speaking children English learners different subgroups of children and when you really break it down back on the previous slide Jenna those subcomponent skills that are under the broader decoding and language covering skills those are those are teaching targets for our teachers right So we want to be teaching through those sub-skills in order to get kids to decode well and also comprehend text and have a robust oral language.

[00:58:10] So we can think about this as both instructionally relevant, and also we know that if children have difficulties in these areas early on, then they're at risk for later reading difficulties. So we can think also through how we're screening and assessing children early. Thank you, Dr. Tsai.

[00:58:27] Questions about the science of reading? Ms. Tolton. Thank you. I'm interested in what percentage of our school divisions, if any, are using curriculum that is aligned with the science of reading and are doing already professional development in service that enables teachers to have these very sophisticated skills in teaching reading.

[00:59:01] And in particular, you know, so have we done some survey of what's going on out there already? And are there any, what I call, found pilots? Who's doing it right already? And what can we learn?

[00:59:16] What results are they getting? So I'll answer it first and see if Dr. Solari has anything to add on the work of the Virginia Literacy Partnership. So I think there are certainly pockets that are happening, right? So when you look at, for instance, there's an example of a nationally known training letters on the science of reading that I believe Dr. Hollins noted that upwards of 100 school divisions are using in some form or fashion.

[00:59:44] I don't think, however, that is like systematic. Every educator, every reading specialist, you know, it sort of gets into every classroom. I mean, and again, I think that we have a long history in the state of funding EIRI, resources towards kind of targeting those kids in most need which is important and continues forward right you know the vla is really meant to work side by side with eir so it's happening in some places but it is not necessarily systematic um and i think that's the big challenge i think similarly we're finding out more and more what curriculum school divisions are using and then the extent

[01:00:24] to which that is consistent across the board right sort of all all classrooms and is that a school division decision or is that a site you know sort of decision um we know that there are places that are using um what we believe to be quality curriculum we've got a process underway to to determine that some of which are products that can be you know purchased nationally and some of which are developed you know by school divisions so we're trying to kind of get that that landscape currently so i don't think it's fair to say that none of this is happening in virginia i think the real shift of the virginal literacy act is to say all kids all classrooms all educators across k3

[01:01:02] so if i may just suggest you may want to do a little looking or for a found model you know in reform efforts i've been involved in in virginia before it's one thing to tell virginia educators that oh somebody in some other state did this but if you can point to well hampton was the one i was working with on foster care reform if they can do it in hampton then you can do it here and I don't I don't know who who if anybody is doing this year but I just encourage you know I think absolutely and then you can show what results they've got I think it's really important and I think I also

[01:01:39] think it's it's critical at least my understanding of talking to and we've heard we'll talk in a second about sort of hundreds of educators who reached out to us you for example folks who have been trained on signs of reading really speak about you very differently about kind of the power that it has and I I think this is just going to emphasize the point that Dr. Mann made earlier, like, you know, it is about equipping people, right, rather than sort of an indictment of what hasn't happened.

[01:02:04] And I think once we equip people with these skills and abilities, it's a game changer. You know, it's truly a game changer. And so we do have examples of that. Ms. Hulton, I think that's exactly right. Like, you're better to hear from another Virginia educator who says, I went through this training. This was a difference maker, you know, with my kids.

[01:02:21] And that is the most powerful testament as we are trying to support more systematic change. So as far as professional development goes, I mean, obviously, as complex as this whole process is, this isn't a one day, four hour PD.

[01:02:40] So how are we going to continually support that development of those teachers that are already in the classroom towards the end goal that we want to want to achieve? Absolutely. I'm going to hold that question as we get into the law and talk about that, though. My question builds on both Ms. Holt and Ms. Creasy just on the higher we talked about this at the last meeting What do we know on higher ed? Are we going to be doing any surveys or anything?

[01:03:04] They're just on sort of adoption of these practices and and how they're being then incorporated in teacher prep programs Yes that we're working with Dr. Johnson and we'll look at both the kind of the current landscape You know both sort of looking at how many candidates you're producing how those candidates are doing kind of what the educator preparation looks like and then also looking at some of the mechanisms around program approval and how you You know sort of you know what shifts if any are needed there. We're doing that type of landscape analysis now fired All right, so had a question. Oh, sorry me

[01:03:45] Is there is there a curiosity and it could be either a few good Is there a curiosity in the department to to see what's happening outside the box? Maybe collaborating or partnering with non-public schools to see what kind of education preparation, what kind of mechanisms they're using, how they're doing, and kind of builds on what Ms. Holton asked about, you know, surveying what others are doing just to see, is there a curiosity to see, you know, obviously there are different skill levels, different educational preparation, and different progress being made children all over the country.

[01:04:25] So is there a curiosity to go that way? I think we're very open to looking at different models, both within the state and across the country. I mean, the good thing is, even though I know Virginia educators prefer to learn from other Virginia educators, like, you know, there are other states that have been slightly ahead of us in terms of implementing these laws, thinking about this training, thinking about how you support educators.

[01:04:49] And instead, I think we'd be very open to hearing from others and looking at kind of models as we explore. one of the things you'll see in the VLA is this idea of us playing a role in vetting and sort of, you know, sort of naming kind of curriculum that work well. We'll talk about the same with some of the professional development. And so if there's models or things we should know about, be very, very curious to learn more. And even if it's within Virginia, then, you know, the non-public sphere to see how our private school is doing. Absolutely.

[01:05:24] Excellent. All right. Let's get into the law itself. And just so I can answer Ms. Creasy's question as well. So really exciting law that passed last year, the Virginia Literacy Act. It's comprehensive. It's multi-pronged. I think it sort of calls on us to collectively do the work that Dr. Mann articulated, passed in a bipartisan way by Delegate Coyner and Senator Lucas, unanimously out of the General Assembly. So it just really kind of creates a positive energy.

[01:05:55] There's funding to support this work. I should note, full implementation is expected by the 24-25 school year. So again, as I said earlier, this will be the first of many of our conversations today. And this is not, does not replace EIRI, right?

[01:06:12] But it's sort of intended to compliment it, you know, as well as sort of think about, as Mr. Rotherham noted, the kind of importance of thinking about what this implies education preparation the i'll go into detail on this but i think it's really important again you're going to hear me use this word over and over again about sort of thinking systematically it's not just enough to think about classroom teachers or families or higher ed you've got to think about both the teachers that are coming into your system and the educators that are currently part of the system what does the ongoing professional development look like and making

[01:06:47] sure we're putting the research at their fingertips and giving them the tools on evidence-based literacy instruction right and really supporting that across the board the law is a long one um and i won't

read every word on this slide but there's a couple of key things i think it's important for this board to understand i think first it defines evidence-based literacy instruction and science-based reading instruction right to kind of create in a world where there's lots of definitions of science of reading what this means for virginia a big shift is calling on this board

[01:07:22] and the department to take a more proactive stance on saying what are high-quality curriculum, core curriculum screening and intervention materials, and to produce a list or a guide on what those materials are, and then begins to require all of our K-3 classrooms to use those.

[01:07:41] It says we need to continue to use our statewide literacy screener and make sure that we are tracking kind of progress over time, and then also says we have to make sure that there are sufficient reading specialists. And I think that's really critical when you think about the challenges of kind of being an educator right now, making sure it's not all on the shoulders of the classroom educator, but there are also specialists who have more sophisticated training and experience to support classrooms. To Ms. Creasy's point, it says we cannot just think about the pipeline. We have to look about the educators that are out there now. Going broader than the educators, we have to think about the principals, the teachers, the reading specialists. I know as we've shared this, we've

[01:08:19] also say we've got to think about the central office staff. We've got to think about the aides, like everybody who is touching the classroom, making sure that they get this professional development ongoing, not just one and done, not just the summer institute on the science-based reading research and this evidence-based literacy instruction. It requires us to partner with families and kind of really create these student-specific reading plans, as well as think about putting these resources at parents' fingertips to support them as they are supporting their children to read and then uh to your to your questions mr roberham really saying we've

[01:08:55] got to take a look at education preparation sort of establish a clear landscape and then making sure that we are aligning all of our systems from licensure to education preparation to program approval so that candidates who come out into virginia schools are fully prepared uh to use evidence-based literacy instruction to teach in k3 yes um i just have a quick question And on the previous slide, Jenna, if you could go back, what is it that you see is the difference

[01:09:32] between supplemental materials and intervention materials? So, and I'll -- we will sort of define this specifically to take it in the reviews, but sort of generally kind of core is like the sort of enough to cover kind of a, you know, the core ELA block every single day.

[01:09:51] Supplemental is kind of covering certain skills or additional areas, and then intervention really the sort of the most sophisticated intensive supports for those children with sort of specific identified needs on the reading specialists the can you help me understand how what was passed uh as part of the literacy act compares to our soq prescription for reading specialists in other words have we got what we had recommended as is what was done as part of the vla

[01:10:29] solved what the board had recommended as part of soq prescription or not yet i don't know the answer to that i do know that we have done analysis and that we we it looks like we currently have sufficient reading specialists to meet this requirement but i i can go back and look at kind of what you all and it may be that the it's a k3 versus uh upper a higher grades question but that uh uh miss baylow if that uh when we talk about the annual report this afternoon there there's an area in an annual report that talks about our soq prescription on reading

[01:11:07] specialists and i couldn't under i i was lacking in clarity on it but the my question here it would be helpful to have that answer when we talk about the annual report thanks i had a question please a couple of questions one is on that first slide maintains the current screening model can you just very briefly what is the current screening model sure so it's this was formerly which is known as pals it's now known as the virginia literacy screener it's in partnership with dr

[01:11:43] salari and the virginia literacy partnerships the office of virgin literacy partnerships it is currently uh going through an overhaul so um yeah as of a year or two ago i think we there was an acknowledgement that we need to go somebody is watching us um so this is the it was known as the pals um it's now the virgin literacy screener we are overhauling it to uh bring it up

[01:12:23] to date with the kind of the best research going back to Mr. Gecker's question earlier kind of really making sure that it is a screener that it kind of identifies some of some of the most important reading difficulties earlier on so it's a multi-year effort we're piloting it now it's a pre-k to a second grade tool we're also doing a spanish version and we pilot we're piloting a bunch of the different measures now we'll come back and then we'll begin to scale it next year

[01:12:55] thank you um and how would you how do you really implement the partnering with families to to do in to for the development of the student reading plans how do you intend to do that so i think it starts with some of the questions you all asked earlier about sort of currently understanding let's sort of the current state i mean we've had for example kind of a set of conversations internally even about you know the extent to which families receive their literacies it results now um and there's quite a bit of variability kind of both within not only kind of across the state

[01:13:35] but even within school divisions and even within school sites and so i think this kind of first understanding kind of the extent to which what schools are or not currently doing around helping supporting their educators to support families to understand where their kids are at um so we're So we're doing that type of kind of analysis now and then I think really thinking through from the kind of what do families need to know sort of about the science of reading.

[01:14:02] Literacy Partnerships, for example, has a set of resources for families on there. What do, as you start to roll out curriculum and look at some of the guidance around using high-quality curriculum, what sort of is relevant for families to understand about the curriculum that you use day in, day out, the supplement and the intervention materials, and also helping understand okay not only how is my child doing but like what do I do about that and I think we have variability right now and even kind of you know do you get your results from your kids like beyond there's sort of a difference just getting the report card but actually getting the kind of the screen or the assessment results and then what do I I do with it so this will also miss data take a sort

[01:14:39] of an agency-wide approach we'll work with the office of parent engagement we'll work the school divisions we have we'll have as I'll talk in a little bit later about families on the advisory work group to kind of help us support and think differently about this but I think we'll first try to get an understanding of where we are where the gaps are and then begin to those just a quick note was that when my kids were in elementary school like parents would sign up to come and read outside of the class but out to read one-on-one with other kids not just their own children that some parents are able to do at home but they would sign up on on a day you know there would be a stack of books and

[01:15:19] they would do one-on-one reading with the child they would probably accomplish five or five to ten kids in that day but things like that yeah yeah well I think it's also to miss Hilton's question earlier sort of identifying what are some of the models or bright spots where this is happening and also sharing that across the board but I do think the law is pretty explicit that we we need to be more proactive about what information is getting to families and not just where kids are at but like what what we can sort of do to help families guardians

[01:15:54] and parents you take action based on that too thank you I would even encourage us that there are some wonderful organizations out there I was on the board of reading this fundamental for probably ten years and the level of community engagement and sometimes we get a little bit caught up in the right type of reading or the right science but there's an awful lot of pockets of the ones that we're trying to reach where just supply is important intervention is important and so and I'm sure this is going on but I I think working with some

[01:16:29] of these types of organizations but also I think to some of the previous comments even waging a bit of a campaign if you will to let parents understand you know where we are where we need to be but also you know its impact for them personally and just I just have 16 grandkids in the system right now and I'm just not sure how much reading is emphasized especially for the K through three students of having parents understand that this is the most important thing with all of the other things that their students or children are in

[01:17:09] school for right now that they need to be taking ownership over in any which way they can. yeah i think that's a great point i think sort of you know the the families say yes i know i need to read nightly right 15 minutes or whatever else but like beyond that as we do have better data and information on children how do we make sure that that's actionable for families and i think that's a great point mr hansen and we talked a little bit about we will include a community-based organization on our advisory work group as well and really thinking about like you know where can we partner where folks have existing relationships with families have done some of this work we do

[01:17:45] not need to reinvent the wheel there it's a great point okay so one of the things it's a lot of law and i've you again i think the key takeaway was articulated earlier it's a significant amount of work and lift for us for our partners we cannot do it alone we can no single office or division at the department can do it we need to partner with higher education we need to partner with families school divisions educators across the state and obviously um with kind of at the core centers of our our work as i've gone out and talked with folks about this and i think thinking

[01:18:21] about this question around like wow this implies change in work you know how how can we make sure that this resonates with folks i think it's it is helpful to have a vision on what will be different as a result of this um you know beyond just the kind of a compliance what does the law say that we we have to do and so we've put out you know one-pagers and had conversations and i'll say you know, quite frankly, this is where I get the most sort of head nodding around where people can agree on the importance of this. And I think that the key piece is you'll notice the word on these slides, the every. And I just, I can't under sort of state that enough, right? A shift

[01:18:57] from kind of a targeted intervention approach to literacy, to really sort of saying a comprehensive every, every student, whether you're in Southwest, Nova, Tidewater, Southside, here in Central, everywhere you'll go, that folks will be using a high-quality approved literacy curriculum for their

core literacy curriculum across all of those classrooms, the entire block, and that we will know kind of where kids are using our screener and then have plans in place, right, with involved families, involved educators, involved reading specialists, if kids are not at the benchmark.

[01:19:35] And this is a big shift for Virginia, which has really sort of said, you know, we've approved things in the past primarily kind of textbooks but now this is really sort of assertively saying and it will be this board that ultimately approves like kind of the list of curriculum that need to be used in classrooms across the state. It will remain a local choice and that's important to note. I do not see the resolution nor does this law ever call for a singular curriculum or a singular supplement or a singular intervention. Choice is important. Engaging sort of not only school divisions and educators in that choice is important as you think about kind of what a big deal it is to change curriculum if you are in a situation

[01:20:13] where you're not currently using something that's that's approved it means that every k3 teacher right needs the supports to be able to use high quality curriculum to transition to said curriculum if they're not using it already they need to be able to support it to regularly assess using the literacy screener and other supplemental tools throughout the year. And that they are really then supported to kind of use that data and really the kind of reading specialist playing a key role to coach and support to identify the needs. And one of the things you hear from our K-3 teachers right now who are dealing with so much is that there's just never been greater variability in

[01:20:52] the system, right? As a result of the pandemic, you have first graders that look like kindergartners and first graders that look like third graders. You have second graders that look like kindergartners, and second graders that look like fourth graders and so really trying to figure out how do we give you strong core materials right to organize your day and support your intentional instruction in both the kind of the the word recognition linguistic comprehension but also you know address the variable needs of of of your of your students um and um to the point that um that miss creasy noted uh that we're really recognizing we have a lot of teachers in the system so while we have to to fix and address the the pipeline we also have to provide supports ongoing

[01:21:30] supports to those educators that are in and the system every reading specialist will make sure that there's more of them and they're sufficient one and they're really kind of partnering with classroom educators to support the needs of the kids who are not on track not on target and doing that in collaboration with teachers and families they also will be critical ambassadors of kind of how do not only take a training or a set of trainings on evidence-based literacy instruction, but turn that into practice. And I know you've heard a lot about that. I know Dr. Siebert and his work in the schools, right? It's like one thing to have a training, right? And then, you know, how do I use

[01:22:08] that next Tuesday and next Wednesday and next Thursday? And we see the reading specialist playing a critical coaching role. So not only supporting, right, here are the kids with the most identified needs, how are you thinking about addressing those kids, but also supporting sort of more broadly, How are you using this evidence-based curriculum?

[01:22:24] How are you applying day in, day out what we now know about the science of reading? It means for our school divisions that each will have a literacy plan and it will be kind of readily available information to your question, Ms. Holton, no matter what curriculum they're using, what supplemental materials, what intervention materials, they are making sure across all of their classrooms that approved curriculum is being used and used consistently, making sure they've got sufficient staff they're partnering

with us so we'll as we'll talk in a second we'll offer some choice around the knowledge based training either a sort of statewide option or if you want something that's

[01:23:00] off a sort of an approved list but they'll make sure that they're getting it to we sort of start off with teachers reading specialists and principals that but the more we talk with school divisions and folks they say we've got a whole array of people who support the classroom that we need to make training and then we will be hiring through regional literacy partnerships, regional literacy coaches for this year, up to eight to kind of support school divisions and to support the reading specialists.

[01:23:28] So kind of different tiers of support across the system. Ms. Dutta, to your questions, what does this mean for families of K-3 students? I think a real focus on making sure that there's readily available information on sort of how kids learn to read, assessment and curriculum so they can support children's literacy development at home, as well as looking at models of volunteering and kind of connection, working with community-based organizations, and, again, making sure that there's a sort of, you know, an action step, an action-oriented reading plan for those kids who are at risk, who they do not meet literacy benchmarks.

[01:24:06] I have a question about that. Please, yeah. So there was, in a local division, they gave free access to tutor.com. And what they found surveyed that only 1.2% of the students less than that were actually using it.

[01:24:26] So it's a free service of their purpose to raise the learning loss and other, you know, reasons. But online resources are not always used very well.

[01:24:47] I feel that there's more like a more manual face-to-face interventions are more helpful. Thank you. No, I think that's a really important point. And so I think we, the minimum is to make sure that they're available. But I agree. I mean, ultimately teachers are such critical ambassadors to families and thinking about kind of what gets sent home, you know, if you use a platform like ClassDojo or, you know, one of those ones, making sure that, you know, that you're sort of, you're basically equipping educators to sort of do some piece of making these resources available because you're exactly right. You might build a website, but it does not mean that they will come. And so I think

[01:25:26] we'll look at how to tackle that. And then as we look at the educator prep programs, again, getting to a place where across the board, across our incredible set of higher education institutions across the state, that there's some consistency in making sure that the coursework, the assessments all line up and that candidates who come out of these programs are fully prepared to be effective in our classrooms using high-quality curriculum materials. So this kind of goes without saying, and maybe I've belabored this point, but it really, truly, it is a lot of work and it takes

[01:26:02] a series of partners and, you know, slightly overwhelming at times to think about this, But I think it's important to recognize how this is such a comprehensive law, because I do think, you know, we've done to sort of some of the points made by Mr. Hanson, Ms. Hulton, Dr. Mann, we have done pieces of this in Virginia, for sure, right?

[01:26:27] I mean, Virginia is a sort of a forward thinking state. And so it's not as though we have not done any of this, but we haven't necessarily done it in a comprehensive way that's focused on all kids, all classroom, all educators, all families. and that requires thinking broadly about from our policymakers to our community-based organizations to higher education how do we all work together to tackle these

challenges so okay so what does this mean in terms of uh implementation so we've begun as soon as the law was signed we've been getting working on this we have an extensive gantt chart and project plan and all of the things that

[01:27:03] kind of to kind of organize our work internally the top priorities for us beyond getting the word out and we've done a superintendent below has done webinars we've been out there speaking to superintendents and school elementary school principals and school boards associations and others but the key thing to get up is we've got to establish a process a rigorous multi-phase process for evaluating the materials so that we can bring lists to you all for approval we're starting with core curriculum and then we'll move on to supplemental and intervention materials and basically it's you know we could we'll talk probably next month in more detail about how

[01:27:40] this looks but really kind of running a very rigorous process so that you all can trust when we bring materials to you for approval that they've been fully vetted fully checked and that if approved and used in virginia classrooms that they will be the types of tools that support our educators to be successful we'll also this year be developing guidelines and tools for the student-specific reading plan and thinking about how we roll that out and sort of even thinking you must add on some of those questions about how do you get this to parents and engage families on that, not just sort of an after the fact there. And Ms. Creasy, we're thinking about right now

[01:28:15] the statewide training. And so really there's kind of two pathways here. One is which we'll bring a list to you of some of the national folks that are approved to do this training. This is, again, we are not the first state to do this. There are a set of vendors who do provide kind of this knowledge-based training. We'll take a look at those. We'll be able to say, here's the list of folks who do that well. We also know that's expensive, that's time-consuming, that's variable, and so that won't be the only option. Instead, we'll be partnering with Virginia Literacy Partnerships, Dr. Solari and her team, to develop a statewide option that will sort of be oriented with a set of literacy coaches at UVA who will then be sort of assigned to reading specialists,

[01:28:54] and then we will create kind of a hybrid model that there'll be online content to be supported with in-person kind of coaching and support over time so there might be some activity in the summer and then there'll be kind of like a monthly sort of module plus you know kind of uh involving the reading specialist in-person component and so that will allow us to get some scalability it'll allow us to design a tool that works well for virginia educators and it also will allow for some redundancies and we know that you know you might have a teacher who's there but the next year you've got another new teacher right and so kind of really making sure that we've got a model there

[01:29:31] so developing out those modules regional literacy partnerships has already developed some of those and then really thinking about the literacy coach to reading specialist model that allows for an in-person component that sort of both gives some individual coaching but also helps connect really the application of the information in the classroom day in day out so two options there one will be the state model and one will be the kind of off-the-shelf products that are that are available and then lastly starting by the by towards the end of the year on the guidance and tools for the literacy plans for the school divisions what does this mean for you all so the first box you

[01:30:07] can check today you're becoming familiar with the vla and the timeline activities we will talk with you at a future work session about the kind of curriculum material process i'll bring dr salari and we

will get into the weeds about all the steps that we're taking and how we're working with Virginia educators, hundreds of Virginia educators across the state, to review lots of materials before we bring them to you. But ultimately, this body will need to approve a list that we will then turn around to school divisions and educators and say you've got to choose from this list. There'll be several rounds of this, so we won't just get this one meeting

[01:30:43] done or two meetings done, but we'll bring to you sort of several sets of this. We will also similarly bring to you a list of the knowledge-based professional development. So again, you'll approve a list of kind of high quality national vendors um you know and and know that that will be an option for school divisions in addition to the statewide options and potentially summer into next year uh guidance for the student-specific reading plans and the division-wise literacy plans so again bringing materials some of the materials articulated in the law to you all for vetting and approval before rolling out to the field um when you look at other states that

[01:31:18] have done instructional material reviews I just want to kind of clarify there will be multiple rounds multiple rounds and really what we will do is spend a lot of time working with you to kind of believe in our process because it's a lot of work to kind of review and make sure that these are top top-notch materials and want to and obviously there's lots of stakes here right in terms of like vendors and educators who care about these materials and so really making sure that you feel confident in the process that we have embarked on when we bring these materials to you for the school divisions right now they're focused on awareness there are resources and we work closely with the literacy partnerships to make sure folks

[01:31:58] who want to get this underway now we're trying to understand as miss Holton asked about who's doing this well kind of these pockets across the state and how we can learn from them but kind of spreading the word about about this we've asked them to submit their curriculum and so we've got a set of curriculum that are already in the process of being reviewed this can be commercial products or they can be curriculum that developed by educators within school division so we take we'll take both for the reviews process and then we're beginning to orient them on understanding that these new things like student-specific reading plans are rolling out we're working and running numbers to help them understand on the reading specialist ratios and

[01:32:36] making sure that they're covered there and again we'll start to roll out plans for the training starting with the reading specialist next summer and making sure that they are getting all of their reading specialist excuse me into that training starting next year it's a lot of preparation for next year we've been asked this question a lot you know does this mean we have to use approved curriculum in the 23 24 school year the answer is no again remember full implementation is 24 25 so we don't want people just to sort of put it off for a year and a half because you know deciding on and implementing a curriculum takes time and that's why we're moving urgently on the review

[01:33:13] the instructional material reviews process but just as a reminder the full implementation is not required until the 24-25 school year um and then that means we've so that means we've got a lot to do as well in 23-24 so multiple rounds coming to you all for approval on core curriculum supplemental intervention materials we'll be rolling out the statewide training getting to all of the key constituencies reading specialists educators principal aids and others at this point we'll also, Mr. Rotherham, really be working with higher ed, partnering with them to kind of begin to say what is, how do you, you know, sort of understand where we are, what changes are needed.

[01:33:51] That may also be things we'll bring to the board, probably not this year, right, but in future years if there are changes needed to program approval or licensure. And again, really making sure we're pushing out tools in the 23-24 year that we expect school divisions to be using. And 24-25, noting um as mr sievert knows like you just these are not these are battleships you cannot shift them overnight and so trying to put these tools at school divisions fingertips sooner rather than later as they support the implementation yes mr if you may ask a question i had a question about in one of the previous slide talked about statewide training beginning in summer 2023

[01:34:29] so what what kind of trainings and how how would it be implemented for this is for teachers these are for reading specialists so yes what kind of training are we talking about so this is what we're calling knowledge-based training so some of the training on evidence-based literacy instruction and the science of reading and so there'll be two options there's a set of vendors that already do this and we will bring a list of you of those that we think are high quality and you're going to prove those and school divisions can choose if they would like to use

[01:35:04] those with their reading specialists and their educators and others we will also provide a statewide option and that will develop in partnership with eva virginia literacy partnerships and they um the law calls on them to hire a set of literacy coaches who in turn will support reading specialists and so we'll develop these online modules um and then so and then we will do the kind of in person so you can almost imagine your online module and then there'll be sort of a guide that will support the online the sort of the in-person work like a conference or so i think There might be some sort of conference or institute-like events to kick off, but I think

[01:35:43] what we've learned, we look kind of nationally at best practices, that's just not sufficient. So we're trying to think about what's a scalable, sustainable model that is not just kind of a quote one and done, but that would get to folks periodically over time.

[01:35:58] And so that's what we're designing and building out right now. Thank you. Is that helpful? Yeah. I was just maybe going to follow up on what I mentioned earlier, too, where I think it would be beneficial in maybe the outreach to parents and kind of the communication or campaign awareness for them, understanding what's coming.

[01:36:24] And they can also be doing it, I think, especially as it gets into the third bullet on evaluating those students which are not, and maybe the subgroups or others as well. It just seems like that ought to be part of the key activities for the divisions to make sure that there's a component for that or whether it's folded into several of these.

[01:36:48] Absolutely. I'd be interested about the plans to begin to work. When are you planning to begin to work with the EDPEP programs? And in particular, I have heard from some of my colleagues that there's a group of literacy specialists from the ed prep programs around the state who are eager to begin to engage with you all and I know you're swamped but are you they've been reaching out are you going to be able to engage with them soon they we are we

[01:37:25] are sort of engaging with them I know some of folks from the department have met with the VCLE and and sort of engage there we're answering questions as we speak and supporting them they you were where possible we'll talk about engagement in a second we're asking folks to kind of weigh in on bits and pieces so for example right now 50 plus of our partners in higher ed are actually reviewing one of the rubrics and offering us their their feedback um this week and in response to them saying hey we would

like a chance to take a look at this and suggestion and so we're um revising the rubric that we'll use for phase two now the

[01:38:03] instructional materials based on their on their fantastic feedback so i think we're trying to think both about how do we engage them more broadly on the vla activities that are occurring right now um and then working really closely with with dr johnson uh about the sort of the education preparation too so kind of both both at sort of both aspects right both as experts in their field around some of the stuff that's you know more relevant to the day-to-day practice of school divisions and then also on the um educator preparation program pieces too miss crucy sorry what another question for you so are are these timelines on the division um what we have

[01:38:42] as far as division-wide kinds of uh timelines we have a lot of very conscientious and and very ambitious school divisions that are probably chomping at the bit to have some more defined timelines out there, where do we see those coming so that they can start to prepare themselves and get everything ready from their perspective? Yeah, no, I think that's, I mean, so I would say, Ms. Creasy, that most urgency and, you know, an understandably and well-appreciated question is, when is this list coming out, right? And the extent to which really kind of understanding,

[01:39:20] I mean, for both aspects, one, am I currently using something that's already approved, which has a pretty significant impact on implementation then you're more thinking about kind of the training and making sure it's every less classroom and if not that's a really big lift right to sort of imagine a shifting curriculum across all of your your k-3 classrooms so we our goal is to bring the list to you all by the summer i will say that our superintendents would have liked it to be sooner than that um when i when i shared that with them last week and there was some visible and oral notification of that of their of their slight frustration with that on the other hand we have to get this right um and i think really making sure that they're the

[01:39:57] right phases and the right rigor we've involved as i'll talk in a second hundreds of virginia educators in the review process these are really lengthy materials you think about kind of what a core curriculum is and how many hours it covers over 180 days a full school year it's just a lot and so um we as we get that process underway it is helping us understand you more specifically when we think we can bring you lists how many rounds we're going to need so that there's a long enough list and sufficient of lists um and so we we know that there is an ask out there for a more specific timeline we want to get a little bit more work underway but we know that it's it's there and

[01:40:33] that will be helpful anybody else um so we've got dr solari on the phone and i just really want to emphasize this really important partnership with the university of virginia virginia literacy partnerships um having kind of national experts in addition and we're partnering more broadly with higher ed so it's not just about working with uva but we're explicitly working with this group this virgin literacy partnership is in charge as you asked about earlier miss dada of our virginia literacy screener and has been for a long time in the commonwealth um and what we are also doing is

[01:41:12] is funding them to support this work so it is a big lift for the video it's taking all of us to support this but we don't have the the full expertise and capacity and so being able to count on experts to help us develop this process to look at the national best practices to make sure we have high quality rubrics that we then have shared with other states we've done this before we've shared with educator virginia educators and we've shared with as i just mentioned miss holton virginia higher ed really important and

kind of building this capacity similarly on the training we need to bring in experts to help us develop a model that sort of meets Virginia's unique needs

[01:41:49] scalable sustainable um and it's you know we just we simply don't have the capacity at the video to do that so we are partnering very closely with Virginia Literacy Partnerships they're helping us develop this process at some point we will we will bring it back into the DOE as they help us develop this capacity learn how to do it we'll take over the tools and the templates but they're helping us run it right now and they're for example also engaging hundreds of Virginia educators They're going to help us design the statewide curriculum, make sure these modules are high quality.

[01:42:18] They'll help us develop the template for the reading plan and provide sort of the technical assistance to divisions. And they will hire and supervise the literacy coaches. So, again, really important that we're bringing in top talent, not only within the agency, but working with partners to do that. And really thinking about how we get the best in class resources.

[01:42:36] This is critical and this will help for cohesion and alignment that they're also in charge of literacy screeners. So that you have, when you think about the importance of identifying kids and aligning kind of identification with instruction, making sure that this is cohesive. What you don't want to have is being like, here's an assessment that evaluates one thing, which is totally disconnected from what we sort of value in the curriculum, which is disconnected from the training that educators are getting.

[01:42:59] So really focusing on expertise, capacity, and alignment as we do this work. So not only kind of across these multiple divisions within VDOE, a big lift for us, but then working closely with Virginia Literacy Partnerships and funding them to do this work so that we can learn from what's done in other states, but also design something that works best for Virginia.

[01:43:24] They also, because they've run the screener for years and years, to your vote, Ms. Houlton, they have good relationships on the ground with many Virginia divisions. so again being able to highlight some of the bright spots and places where people are doing as well just one follow-up question to the conversation earlier about pals and leading indicators etc if we had the pals charts showing change over time would they show basically the same trend as

[01:43:57] nape and fourth grade reading shows of of stable then beginning to drop before the pandemic and then dropping with the pandemic and then starting to uh come back after the pandemic or do we know that yet and if that's not an easy answer i'd love to uh have you all get if you could get us those pals charts at some point that would be helpful emily you want to answer yeah i can i can briefly respond to that so yeah it really is very much the same trend um where we had some increasing levels of children below benchmark right before the pandemic and then of course that number shot up in the middle of the pandemic and then we've had some what we're

[01:44:37] calling a bit of recovery um especially last spring spring of 2022 um there were fewer children um below benchmark although that's not back to pre-pandemic levels does that help yeah yes and if i understood correctly you said there was as with the other trends there was uh some what i would characterize as stability before the pandemic and then a drop within the year or two before the pandemic would that be that's that is correct yeah thank you very helpful any other questions for

[01:45:12] dr salari we've got her here too please dr sievert um so on this topic of virginia literacy partnerships um my question is you know to what extent and what capacity are again obviously uva is in in

the lead here are we bringing the other higher institutions involved in this because it first of all they need to be at the table secondly when it's time to put boots on the ground and to make things happen in division, geography matters.

[01:45:42] Yeah, so I think that's critical, and I think that's both a role for the VDOE, and I know as well, Dr. Solari also engages and has had conversation with these various groups. So, I'll talk in a second. It's a nice segue into engagement.

[01:45:58] We are going to create a Virginia Literacy Act advisory work group, and we started by naming, so we would say we have at least one higher partner, although they've asked for it too. And so we'll make sure that we have higher ed partners as part of that group meeting at a minimum quarterly to walk through these things, have folks at the table, help us kind of kick the tires on, okay, what is working and what are we missing? And how do we think differently about that? So making sure all the groups are there, higher education, community-based organization,

[01:46:35] families, reading specialists, middle school, early childhood principals, chief academic officers, school boards, out of school time, you know, quite a bit, received over 185 applications for this group. Yeah. The only thing that was more popular was to be a reviewer with Dr. Solari's team for the curriculum review. So a ton of interest from Virginia educators, which is just super exciting and mildly overwhelming, but we are kind of pulling that group together.

[01:47:05] in December, and we will make sure that higher ed is featured there. We don't think that's where it ends, Dr. Siebert. I think also as we think about these, really the sort of the literacy coaches that will be part of Dr. Solari's team is thinking about kind of, you know, how do we also have folks at a regional level who are kind of convening and partnering, right?

[01:47:27] Not only working with the reading specialists, but also thinking about how do we interact and intersect with the higher ed and community college institutions in those in those regions i think that's really really important um and and looking at um you know sort of similarly as we get aligned um curriculum materials and we're thinking about you know supports around curriculum based professional development and looking at kind of what which higher eds mean really putting data for example at higher ed's fingertips and i hear the curriculum that are being used within your your broader catchment area and you know how are you supporting that work and realigning if you've

[01:48:04] got candidates that are coming out of your institutions and using those so i think there's multiple opportunities for partnership kind of beyond just the work on educator preparation so we will launch the advisory work group next month in december um we've had real success we've done something similar on the pals task force and bringing folks together across the state we'll make sure all the superintendent regions are reflected we've got a diverse set of stakeholders and kind of you know making sure we're getting insights from that group as i said before we sought virgin literacy partnerships sought application for folks to be reviewers and we

[01:48:40] see nearly 200 applications there and so the approved materials that we will bring to you will have been vetted by virginia educators and virginia experts i think that's really important we've got a separate task force that we uh engage on the new literacy screener Which is great. We had the opportunity to participate actually and talk with those folks a week or two ago And this data that was the group where we realized that we had such wide variability and what parents know now Or kind of have access to whether it's volunteer opportunities or knowing whether or not they even get their PALS Results that was a

question I would imagine Mr. Hansen if you were to ask the you know your for your 16 grandkids like just do a survey of who's in

[01:49:19] You know k2 and who you know where they got the PAL scores and you know whether that was explained to them and just even the engagement around that, we just see tremendous variability. And that was something that we learned really through the task force on the screener. And then we have, we've been on a bit of a roadshow and we'll continue to do that in these early stages, really thinking through both making sure folks are aware of the Virginia Literacy Act, what it calls for, what success looks like. And then to both Dr. Siebert's point and Mr. Hansen's, thinking about opportunities for partnership. So I don't, something this big really takes all of us. And I think we remain curious and open to, have you thought about doing

[01:49:58] this? Or have you heard about this model? Or is there a way within this community that we can do this? And I do think every time we've gone out and spoken, I had a great, I was out in Southwest, out in Abingdon two or three weeks ago and sat next to an incredible elementary school principal from Galax. And we were talking about, you know, the lift around curriculum and shifting curriculum.

[01:50:17] She had just, in response to some of her early childhood efforts, changed her pre-K curriculum and talking about the importance of engaging educators around that choice and their excitement around it. And it was this helpful reminder for me around beyond the compliance and the enormousness of this law.

[01:50:33] Like if you can get people excited about it, there's nothing more than a principal or educator or family member wants than to help that kid to learn to read. And so we on this roadshow are continuing to look at additional partnership opportunities. And thinking outside of the box around how to engage as many people as possible as we seek to implement this over the next three to five years.

[01:50:56] I thought this was going to be like 45 minutes, but you guys must be starving. And that might help me in terms of, you know, wrapping up questions. But let me pause there, Mr. Gecker, and see if there's any additional questions for me or for Dr. Solari. Thank you all so much. I know this is a lot of information.

[01:51:13] Thanks very much. Wonderful. Thank you. Thanks for the great work. Yeah, I think as it has been noted, I think we're up for lunch now, right? So we will take the break, we're 25th, 25th floor for lunch.